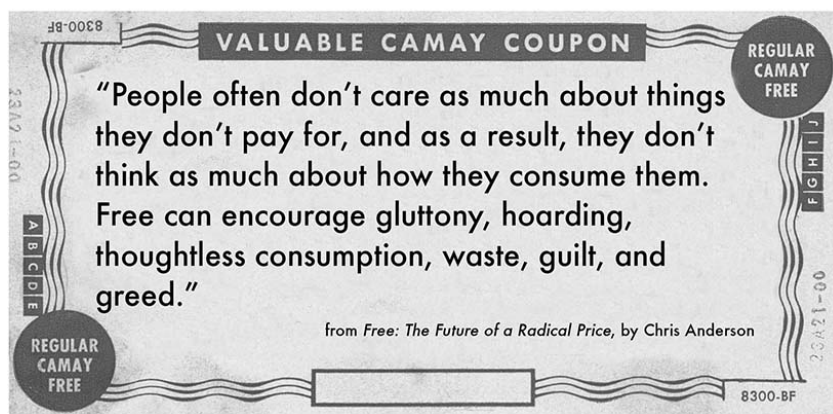


*bandages were free*, I not only failed to correct my children on the proper use of bandages, I actually encouraged their play, with the use of additional bandages. It was only later, when I saw the carnage of empty boxes in my bathroom cupboard, that I questioned the advisability of allowing children to waste something just because it happened to be free. I emptied the remaining boxes into a container with a tight-fitting lid and put it out of the children's reach. But the fact remained; I had definitely devalued a product because it had been free. As I reflected on these things, I was uncomfortably aware that I had occasionally "crossed the line" in my couponing and stockpiling behavior.

In addition to these remembrances of years past, researching coupon fraud and conducting searches on the auction site eBay left a bad taste in my mouth. It became apparent that a dark underbelly of the coupon world exists, despite the best efforts of people like Bud Miller of the CIC and honest coupon advocates like Jill Cataldo.



As if all this insight and contemplation weren't enough, what really changed my coupon hobby during the writing of this book was the